

The Decision to Hold Back: Experimental Evidence on Teachers' Repetition Biases

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Introduction: Grade Repetition

- Grade repetition can be seen as a **double punishment**: students face academic failure and are separated from their peers.
- This separation may negatively affect **self-esteem** and perceptions of ability.
- In psychology, this relates to **learned helplessness**: students stop trying because they believe success is impossible regardless of effort.
- Overall, the literature finds **little or no positive effects** of grade repetition on test scores, skills or dropout rates

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Our approach

- Our novel approach: we focus on teachers and their 'harshness' level
- We carry out a survey experiment in Spain, where the grade repetition rate more than doubles that of the OECD (9% and 22%)
- Double objective:
 - ① Characterizing 'harsh' teachers
 - ② Studying how teachers behave under different policy circumstances

Our approach: What is harshness?

Socioeconomic questionnaire → Experimental section → Behavioral questionnaire

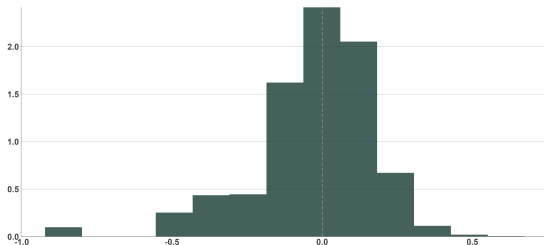
	Option 1	Option 2
Gender	Male	Female
Disadvantaged background	Yes	No
Failed 3 or more subjects	Yes	No
Lacks mathematical and/or linguistic abilities	Yes	No
Has committed a serious or very serious infraction or has been suspended	Yes	No
Frequently misses class without justification	Yes	No

Our approach: Measures of harshness

We estimate 4 different measures, but due to their similarity, only show results for one:

- 1 Number of repetitions
- 2 **Average deviation with respect to peers ($\simeq 320$)**
- 3 Average deviation with respect to predicted probability of repetition
- 4 Average deviation with respect to predicted probability of repetition in a more complete model

Figure: Average deviation with respect to peers



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Characterizing harsh teachers: the model

Figure: Coefficients of linear regression on harshness

